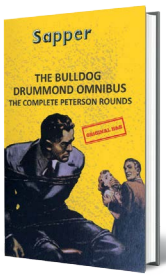
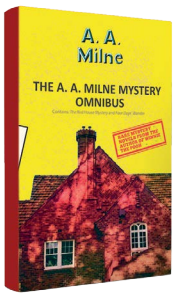
BOOKS

GUILTY PLEASURES

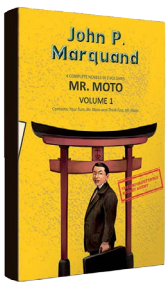
Hachette India's ***The Great Yellowbacks*** *is a retro revival series of classic crime fiction and thrillers from the mid-18th century all the way to the 1960s*

THE BULLDOG DRUMMOND OMNIBUS: The Complete Peterson Rounds
by Sapper
HACHETTE
₹1,299; 996 pages





THE A.A. MILNE MYSTERY OMNIBUS
by A.A. Milne
HACHETTE
₹699; 472 pages



THE MR. MOTO OMNIBUS
by John P. Marquand
HACHETTE
₹699; 516 pages

Are you the kind of deviant who is transfixed by tales of cruelty, murder, casual sexism, racism, and colonial nostalgia with a hearty dash of imperialist adventurism and occult obscurantism thrown in? Well, you're clearly a connoisseur, and earlier this year the elegant publishing house Hachette (they are French, after all) launched its distinctive 'Yellowbacks' series to cater to the apparently burgeoning number of readers seeking just such guilty pleasures. The 200-odd titles in the series (some combined in omnibus volumes) represent an ambitious attempt to repackage 'lost' treasures of vintage popular fiction for an upscale Indian readership.

While reprints of public domain 'classics' have been fair game for publishers for some time now, you're not likely to see any of the titles in the Hachette series stacked in the hands of a fast-talking salesboy at a traffic light. These books are mostly priced at more than Rs 600 and their retro design explicitly invokes the pulpy aesthetics of the now highly collectible mass market 'Yellow Jackets' published by Hodder & Stoughton in the early- and mid-1900s. The British firm was acquired by Hachette in 2004 but the current series does not seek to literally replicate the 400 or so original Yellow Jacket titles, although many of the most famous authors

Trouble in Paradise

Besides being a mystery novel, **Nilima Rao**'s *A Disappearance in Fiji* is also a critique of the indenture system



A DISAPPEARANCE IN FIJI
by Nilima Rao
BONNIER BOOKS
₹399; 288 pages

Kunti is a labourer on one of the sugar plantations in Fiji, as is her husband. One day, she disappears from the 'coolie' lines leaving the family behind. A Sikh police officer based in Suva, the capital, is put on her case. Has the pretty young woman eloped, has she been kidnapped, or even possibly murdered?

Nilima Rao's *A Disappearance in Fiji* is a page turner, an impressive debut novel. The author describes herself as 'culturally confused', being ethnically Indian, born in Fiji and living in Australia from the age of three. This is a mystery novel, but it also pays homage to the country of her birth, where her ancestors arrived from India as indentured labourers to work in the plantations owned by Australians.

Indentureship was a form of fixed-term slavery under which illiterate and impoverished Indians were taken to faraway places like Fiji, Mauritius and Trinidad to work for a pittance for five years minimum. Their employers had complete control on their lives. This servitude programme was established by the Indian government under British rule. After five years you had a choice, take a free passage back to India, sleeping on decks on converted cargo ships, or you could stay back and start a new life.

Between 1879 and 1916, more than 60,000 Indians were persuaded by unscrupulous agents to make the trip to Fiji. About half of them stayed back. Rao's great-grandparents were among those who stayed.

The novel is set in 1914. Akal Singh, the Sikh police officer, has recently been transferred to Fiji from another British colony, Hong Kong. It was his punishment for a major professional blunder. Singh is not happy in this so-called tropical paradise and would rather be back where he came from or his native village in Punjab.

Singh is held in contempt by his superiors at the police headquarters in Suva. To get rid of him, the inspector-general dispatches him to solve